

It was a terrible disappointment to those who could remember seeing what it was like 70 years earlier.

Nothing was in good condition. Everything was broken and torn apart.

God had originally given he land to the descendants of Abraham. He had made a promise to Abraham (Genesis 13:15).

¹⁵ for all the land that you see I will give to you and to your offspring forever. ¹⁶ I will make your offspring as the dust of the earth, so that if one can count the dust of the earth, your offspring also can be counted. ¹⁷ Arise, walk through the length and the breadth of the land, for I will give it to you.” (Ge 13:15–17) .

The Land belonged to God, and the people of Israel had to continue to “pay rent” by obeying God’s rules (Leviticus 25:23).

“The land shall not be sold in perpetuity, for the land is mine. For you are strangers and sojourners with me. ²⁴ And in all the country you possess, you shall allow a redemption of the land. _ (Le 25:23–24) .

The bottom line was that the people had not obeyed God and He had punished them by having them taken into captivity in a country hundreds of miles away.

Where did they begin? If a fire destroyed your home, and you were able to rebuild it, where would you begin?

First, the builders needed to find a place for their families to live in safety – Ezra 2:70

Now the priests, the Levites, some of the people, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the temple servants lived in their towns, and all the rest of Israel in their towns. Rebuilding the Altar (Ezra 2:70–3:1).

You’ve got to eat and sleep and raise your family. Before the people could begin to rebuild the Temple, they had to prepare homes for their families who needed safe places to eat and sleep. We see that before actually doing any work of rebuilding the Temple this was needed first. Wild animals like snakes, lizards, and scorpions needed to be brought under control – not to mention lions and dangerous predators. Only then could the work get underway.

Likewise, believers today, in order to give God the worship and honor He deserves, must get their own homes in order. Imagine a person working in the Temple who has to stop his work because a king has just eaten his youngest child. Even today we must do all that we can to provide for the safety and needs of those we love. If we can’t we need help from God and from others. But if we are able we must do all we can, and then we will be able to do God’s work faithfully and obediently.

How can believers get their homes in order? Especially if your in a place like this how can you help your family while you’re here?

For those of you with children under 18 years of age there is something you can do that will let your children know that you love them. It’s a project named Angel Tree. Very, very soon we will be giving out forms so that your children can receive gifts given in your name at Christmas. I know it’s early, but this is the time you need to get ready.

Chap. Crossland will be organizing this. We will have the forms to fill out, and then you can return them to the housing unit representatives. Stay tuned.

For those of you who don’t have children at home, there is still much that you can do to get your house in order. This Father’s Day commit yourself to being a better father to your sons and daughters, or perhaps being a good substitute Father to some children who need a good father substitute. We live in a society where many fathers are away from their children – there are good things each of us can do to make things better.

Maybe your own earthly father wasn't the greatest, and maybe he was. But you have a perfect Heavenly Father, who has literally moved heaven and earth for your benefit. This Father's Day commit yourself to being a better son to your Heavenly Father. God is building you into His glorious dwelling place. Let God's presence in your life be felt by the members of your family. If you have no children at home, let God's presence in your life be felt by those who live with you and the neighbors who live near you. That is a challenge every believer, including myself, needs to follow.

Next, Fund Raising, Gathering Materials

Ezra 2:68 (donations of money)

Some of the heads of families, when they came to the house of the Lord that is in Jerusalem, made freewill offerings for the house of God, to erect it on its site. (Ezra 2:68) .

Ezra 1:7 (given materials)

Cyrus the king also brought out the vessels of the house of the Lord that Nebuchadnezzar had carried away from Jerusalem and placed in the house of his gods. (Ezra 1:7) .

Ezra 1:9-11 (a list)

And this was the number of them: 30 basins of gold, 1,000 basins of silver, 29 censers, 10 30 bowls of gold, 410 bowls of silver, and 1,000 other vessels; 11 all the vessels of gold and of silver were 5,400. All these did Sheshbazzar bring up, when the exiles were brought up from Babylonia to Jerusalem. (Ezra 1:9-11).

Getting everything that was needed was an essential part of building the Temple. We might find it to be a trivial detail, but the Temple would have never been built if gathering the needed funds and materials never took place. There are a lot of details that go into living a life dedicated to God that can seem pointless at the moment we experience them, but they are all part of what we need to do to follow and obey Him.

Getting Right with God by the Right Sacrifice

A sacrifice on the altar (Ezra 3:2&3)

² Then arose Jeshua the son of Jozadak, with his fellow priests, and Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel with his kinsmen, and they built the altar of the God of Israel, to offer burnt offerings on it, as it is written in the Law of Moses the man of God.

³ They set the altar in its place, for fear was on them because of the peoples of the lands, and they offered burnt offerings on it to the Lord, burnt offerings morning and evening (Ezra 3:2-3) .

This was before anything else of the Temple was built, not even the foundation (Ezra 3:6)

⁶ From the first day of the seventh month they began to offer burnt offerings to the Lord. But the foundation of the temple of the Lord was not yet laid. (Ezra 3:5-6) .

The people recognize that before they did anything else the first step in building the Temple was to offer a sacrifice to God. Not just any sacrifice would do. It had to be the right kind of sacrifice. Even the altar has to be built a very specific way that God has directed. This was the first step in restoring proper worship. It has to be done correctly or God would not accept it.

What is our sacrifice?

Jesus died on the cross, and only what Jesus did can bring us into a right relationship with God.

The Old Testament Sacrifices pointed ahead to Jesus' sacrifice on the cross (Hebrews 7:26-27).

²⁶ For it was indeed fitting that we should have such a high priest, holy, innocent, unstained, separated from sinners, and exalted above the heavens. ²⁷ He has no need, like those high priests, to offer sacrifices daily, first for his own sins and then for those of the people, since he did this once for all when he offered up himself. (Heb 7:26-27) .

Does that mean that we sacrifice nothing to God?

From God's point of view, Jesus offered Himself as a sacrifice for our sins, and God recognized that sacrifice as acceptable. (1 John 4:9; 14).

⁹ In this the love of God was made manifest among us, that God sent his only Son into the world, so that we might live through him. ¹⁰ In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins. (1 Jn 4:9–10) .

¹⁴ And we have seen and testify that the Father has sent his Son to be the Savior of the world. (1 Jn 4:13–14) .

From our point of view Jesus' gives Salvation and Forgiveness as a free gift, that we do not deserve (Romans 3:21-26). All the sacrifices, the role of the priests, the sacred holidays, and the Temple itself, all pointed to Jesus, His death on the cross, and His resurrection.

²¹ But now the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, although the Law and the Prophets bear witness to it— ²² the righteousness of God through faith in Jesus Christ for all who believe. For there is no distinction: ²³ for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, ²⁴ and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, ²⁵ whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith. This was to show God's righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins. ²⁶ It was to show his righteousness at the present time, so that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus. (Ro 3:21–26) .

We respond by giving ourselves to God as Jesus gave Himself for us.

In grateful response to God's priceless gift, we sacrifice our bodies to God (Romans 12:1&2).

¹² I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship. ² Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that by testing you may discern what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect. (Ro 12:1–2) .

In a joyful response of thanksgiving, we praise God (Hebrews 13:15). That is also a sacrifice that we give to God.

¹⁵ Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the fruit of lips that acknowledge his name. (Heb 13:15).

Our sacrifices do not earn anything, but they express joyful gratitude. Only Jesus' sacrifice is sufficient to earn our salvation.

Father's Day

Even after being rejected God continued loving His people.

This Father's Day is an opportunity to rest in your Heavenly Father's love, and to share His love with others. This can include your sons and daughters, and those who are like sons and daughters to you.

Our Heavenly Father has loved us in a spectacular way. Many who believe in Jesus know the most often quoted verse that speaks of this love: ¹⁶ "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life. (John 3:16, ESV).

God is building true believers into a family and household that will be eternal and vastly superior to anything any of us have ever known.

Do you want to be part of the family and household that God is creating?

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Some of the **heads of families**, when they came to the **house** of the **LORD** that is in **Jerusalem**, made **freewill offerings** for the **house** of God, to **erect** it on its **site**. **According** to their **ability** they **gave** to the **treasury** of the **work 61,000 darics of gold**, **5,000 minas** of silver, and **100 priests'** garments. Now the **priests**, the Levites, **some** of the **people**, the singers, the gatekeepers, and the **temple** servants lived in their **towns**, and all the rest of **Israel** in their **towns**. **When** the **seventh month came**, and the children of **Israel** were in the **towns**, the **people** gathered as one man to **Jerusalem**. Then arose Jeshua the son of Jozadak, with his fellow **priests**, and Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel with his kinsmen, and they built the **altar** of the God of **Israel**, to **offer burnt offerings** on it, as it is written in the Law of Moses the man of God. They set the **altar** in its place, for fear was on them because of the **peoples** of the lands, and they **offered burnt offerings** on it to the **LORD**, **burnt offerings** morning and evening. And they kept the **Feast** of Booths, as it is written, and **offered** the daily **burnt offerings** by number **according** to the rule, as each day required, and after that the regular **burnt offerings**, the **offerings** at the new moon and at all the appointed **feasts** of the **LORD**, and the **offerings** of everyone who **made a freewill offering** to the **LORD**. From the first day of the **seventh month** they began to **offer burnt offerings** to the **LORD**. But the foundation of the **temple** of the **LORD** was not yet laid. So they **gave** money to the masons and the carpenters, and food, drink, and oil to the Sidonians and the Tyrians to bring cedar trees from Lebanon to the sea, to Joppa, **according** to the grant that they had from Cyrus king of Persia.

([ESV](#))